The Blue Dress

By Reginald Gibbons

ESTHER: [I remember the night] . . .
(Pg 84- 85) you tore my new blue dress
that you couldn't tell from silk
right off my back, left me
naked in a corner with my hands
up and you yelling at me
I spent too much of your money,
said I wouldn't
leave you alone,
made me get in the closet
and locked me in there, shouted
through the door if I ever
tried to leave you, you would
cut me so bad, no one
would want me, while I cried
into a torn rag of my dress,
all ruined and lost and wasted.

That was for you, that dress,
to make you happy, make
you want to be with me.

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INTRODUCTION

According to the National Coalition Against Domestic Violence, an estimated 1.3 million American women are victims of physical assault by a husband or boyfriend each year. The majority of these women continue a relationship with their abuser. But why? Why do battered women stay? The answer given in the 1920s was that battered women were of low intelligence or mentally retarded. In the '40s it was determined that women did not leave because they were masochistic. By the '70s the experts claimed that a woman stayed in an abusive situation because she was isolated from friends and neighbors, had few economic resources, and was terrorized into a state of "learned helplessness" by repeated abuse.

*But you see, the **answer** is not the problem . . . **the problem is the question itself**. "Why doesn't she just leave?" When we ask that question first, we lose sight of the criminal and the crime and begin to place blame on the victim.*

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ESTHER: (Pg 78 – 86)

You tore it off my back.

But I'm not good
at telling a story -- you'd shut
me up by saying that --
so I guess I can't tell this one,
that had to do with the way
I once used to feel
when someone like you
who had done a rough kind
of work -- work that can kill you
if you're not careful -- talked
to me like my listening
was important to him.
And listened
to me, too, made me feel
I could be the gentleness
he needed after bad
times -- someone who'd grown
up hard and alone, like you,
or gotten through the war
alive. . . But I don't feel
the same about you any-
more, or nearly anyone,
any man, I've known.
I thought when I met you
and it was exciting to me
to be with you, it was
more life I was getting --
and it was less.

But you said I was special,
I was the best of all
the girls -- the women -- you'd had,
the sexiest, I turned you on
the most. That's what I'd
remember when I'd want
to leave you,
when you'd been
after me again, like always
drunk, hunting me or saying
you'd kill me. I'd try remembering
that nobody else ever told me
I was special or beautiful,
and I thought it was loving
me that made you say it --
I know I'm not pretty
the way some women are,
the way some were that you
would look at twice and make
me forget what you'd done
and want you for myself again.

But it was just being
scared that kept me from leaving,
you saw to that many times.

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And I did used to love you,
I did love your kisses,
love that touch you had for me,
holding my face in your hands,
squeezing my shoulders for me,
the way you'd rub my tired legs
and how you'd put your hands
on *me*, that was so careful,
I thought, not to hurt.
And my gripping you as hard
to me as I could,
and you'd say I was the best of all
of them, the best and the best
till the waves of it hit --
I'd float for a long
second or two and then it
slams through, so sweet.

But you'd hit me. Just sitting
together in the apartment and you'd
jump up and hit me yelling
"Don't do that!" and I don't
even know what it is.
You used your belt on me,
you threw me down the stairs
more than once and locked
me out alone for hours
and I never knew anyone
in the building who I could
go to, I'd just stay down
near the front door inside,
people would come in and go out
and hold the door for me
but I'd say no, I was
waiting

for someone. . .

Till you came down to look.
When you made up to me
I was so happy to have
you back -- back to yourself --
and we'd go out dancing,
you'd know everybody there
and those friends of yours would always
pretend that nothing's wrong.
I felt grateful to them
for treating me so friendly,
so polite, so respectful. Nice.
And they could laugh with me,
in a way you couldn't, or wouldn't.

The preacher says to talk.
So I do and he listens
and doesn't say very much.
He still thinks that all
the bad came from you, that

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everything bad that was done,
you did -- which I'm not going
to tell him any different.
All he knows about that
night is you chased me
downstairs and into the street
at 3 a.m. with me
in my nightgown in the cold and no shoes
and you with the sharp kitchen
knife in your hand, yelling
you were going to cut me.

You never even knew how
afraid I was to go
to sleep and afraid to wait up
for you, too, but what would
you have cared, in those moods –
I went crazy wondering
what you'd do when you came in,
turning like a mean dog
and trying to get me when you
could barely stand up and had
to hold onto the furniture
to walk across the room.

I don't know how you
were able all of a sudden
to move so fast that night,
the state you were in, and the knife
in your hand. Then when you stopped
in the middle of the dead
street and said it was over
and turned around and started
back, I don't know why
I followed you home, either.

I watched you real carefully
when you got into bed
with your clothes on and you put
the knife under your pillow
and said to me that if I
wanted to kill you while you
were sleeping, there it was.

I waited one more hour
watching the clock go slow,
afraid you'd wake up
sick out of your alcohol sleep
and with one of your nightmares.
Then I had to reach under
your pillow to find the knife
and I cut my finger on it --
I almost cried out
but I realized that what I was
was so mad at you that
all of a sudden I wanted
to beat you hard as I could

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with my fists and scream
and it still makes me crazy and I
wish I had done it --
instead. But I didn't
make a sound, just held
my cut finger that I couldn't
look at and looked at you
for a long time, trying
to guess where in you was your heart.

I had a thought and I
went back to the kitchen to put
a bandage on my cut and hold
it till it stopped bleeding
and only throbbed and I called
the police. Come over here
right now, I told them, I'm
going to kill him, and I gave
the address, the apartment,
the floor, the bedroom. . . I wanted
a bunch of them in case
they had to save me from
what you might do while you
were dying.
Or maybe what
I wanted was what they did.

I took the knife and went
first to unlock the door
for when they'd come, wondering
how long it would be. I stood
in the doorway to our room
counting to two hundred
in my mind and then counted
again, and heard them stamping
and running up the stairs
so loud I thought they'd wake you
and I ran to stab your
chest holding the knife in both hands.

It slipped sideways and tore
your shirt down your ribs
and only cut you some.
You jumped and opened your eyes
but it didn't seem like you
could see me and I stabbed you
again and it slipped again,
I couldn't make it go
into you, but too late to stop.

When the cops pulled you off
of me -- I don't know where
the knife went -- know what?
I had to run onto the back
landing outside and pull
the door shut, that always
locks, lock myself out
because you were yelling

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Help me, Esther, help me
please God Esther, help,
they're killing me, Esther!
I would have rushed back
and killed those cops to get
them off of you.

Then the noise was gone away.
I was trying to figure out
how to get back in, freezing
and crying in my nightgown,
they must have taken you away
and what would happen to you
and how could I get you out
somehow when I heard two shots
from the street around front.
I don't know what they've said
you did -- when they came up
calling for me and let me
into our place and told me
what had happened to you
I couldn't seem to hear them.

What I thought of while they
were talking and talking and waiting
for me to say something
that I wasn't going to say
was how I'd last seen one
of them at your back holding
you by the collar the way
you grabbed mine the night
you tore my new blue dress
that you couldn't tell from silk
right off my back, left me
naked in a corner with my hands
up and you yelling at me
I spent too much of your money,
said I wouldn't leave you alone,
made me get in the closet
and locked me in there, shouted
through the door if I ever
tried to leave you, you would
cut me so bad, no one
would want me, while I cried
into a torn rag of my dress,
all ruined and lost and wasted.

That was for you, that dress,
to make you happy, make
you want to be with me.
All I had was a physical
need in my body, for you,
and wanting you to say
you loved me and be nice
the way you used to be.
I kept thinking that if

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I was nicer to you
you'd get better, you'd be
all right again, and I'd
be special to you, like before.
Now nothing can change ever
between us, we'll always
be stuck where we were that night.
Only I'm the only one
to feel it, you can't.

The preacher will tell me I
should forgive you now,
should let it go, should come
to church once in a while,
I look at him and see
another man looking at me.
You used to tell all your
stories to your friends, the hard
knocks you'd had -- you said
harder than mine. Is this
story good enough, you think,
for me to tell it? But you
aren't listening, you can't
answer me, you never did,
you're not here but you won't
go away, and you can't
give me back what you took
if you're dead. If you could
give me back that one dress
then you could give me everything,
even the way one time you put
your hand in my hair after
you had hit me and said
Please don't cry, sugar, don't,
honey, stop crying, please,
I promise to you that
I'll never do it ever again.

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